where factions fighting for control of a country—often trying to introduce democracy to it—had found it necessary to get the country's military on their side.

The truth is, once we had information from Israel that we could trust the people in Iran, I didn't have to think thirty seconds about saying yes to their proposal. What I was saying yes to was the action of another government, Israel. We wouldn't be shipping any weapons to the people in Iran. I was told that the few TOW missiles would not significantly change the balance in Iran's war with Iraq, so I said, okay, we wouldn't stand in the way of this one small shipment from Israel going through to give credibility to the Israelis, allowing them to prove that they were talking with the highest levels of the U.S. government. But I said there was one thing we wanted: The moderate Iranians had to use their influence with the Hizballah and try to get our hostages freed.

Their answer was yes, they would—and could—do it. So I agreed to the plan, which called for release of the hostages on a beach north of Tripoli in September. Israel promised to abort the sale and order their delivery aircraft to turn back with the missiles if it became apparent the hostages were not going to be released.

Only hours after the shipment was made, the Reverend Benjamin Weir, an American who had been held hostage in Beirut for sixteen months, was released. There was a lot of suspense in the White House during the next two days as we waited for the rest of the hostages to be released. We were told their release had been delayed by the terrorists who held them—but that, nevertheless, it was just a matter of time before all six were free. We were disappointed, yes, but we had succeeded in bringing home one of the hostages, and I felt pretty good. Now we all waited for the others to be released.